to have darker skin, ideas that have survived well into the modern age.

By the time the British left, colourism had taken firm root in the Indian psyche. Women came to bear a disproportionate brunt of this unfair burden, as caste, patriarchy and economic status colluded to bestow a sense of inferiority on the less fair. Dark skin was seen as an abomination, from the time relatives in a family set eyes upon a child born dark. Names like Kali or Kaalia were perhaps as common and accepted as euphemisms like Shyam or Shyamolie. Taunts followed into childhood, none more familiar than "*Kaali kaluti, baingan looti*", the colour purple, robbed off an aubergine. The prejudice was perpetuated in school and college, not just by other children but often even by the teachers. Worse was the "internalised racism", or, as Parameswaran says, "people at the receiving end of such discrimination turning around and denigrating those with darker skins". There would be solicitous advice to use home-made remedies such as a *haldi-malai ubatan* or off-the-shelf salves like Vicco Turmeric or Fair & Lovely that promised to make the skin colour lighter.

A 2023 study by researchers at the Institute of Cognitive Science, Osnabrück University, Germany, on colourism in the Indian subcontinent, confirmed these trends. It concluded that the "various skin colour discriminating structures from birth and in all social settings invade the minds of anybody involved and thus structure the ways through which people affectively experience themselves and others. They work as affective scaffolds and tools that lead people to internalise norms and values that conform to superior-inferior parameters of the colour hierarchy. Eventually, people develop an orientation which prefers whiteness against their own best interests."



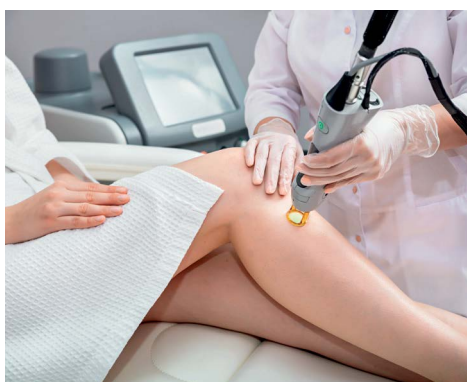
"Our gods—Vishnu, Shiva, Ram, Krishna—are all portrayed as dark-skinned. The association of beauty and aspiration with white skin is a gift of European colonial rulers"

DR VIVEK KUMAR
Professor of Sociology, JNU

THE BEAUTY BAZAAR

The Indian skin lightening market is worth Rs 11,100-12,800 crore today. Here are some of the products that are behind the beauty boom

↘ HELIOS LASER TREATMENT
It involves targeting and breaking down pigment clusters, particularly melanin, to reduce the appearance of dark spots and making the skin tone even
Cost: Rs 4,000 to Rs 35,000 per session



↘ GLUTATHIONE INJECTIONS
A naturally occurring antioxidant in the body, a dose of glutathione helps reduce melanin production and hyperpigmentation, thus making skin tone lighter
Cost: Rs 10,000 to Rs 40,000 per shot

↘ GLYCOLIC PEELS
These use a variety of acids to break down dark spots. However, the results are variable and not as long-lasting as other treatments
Cost: Rs 900 upwards





↘ FACIALS/ BLEACH
The facials could either be lab-made (glycolic acid, kojic acid, niacinamide) or use natural chemicals (haldi, soy, licorice extract) to 'bleach' the skin to a lighter tone. Some facials even use the blood from your own body to boost collagen and cell growth, promising lighter, younger skin
Cost: Varies